06

PART 6 OF 9

Prophets, Exile and Return

2 KGS 17–25; ISA; JER; EZEK; DAN; JONAH; EZRA; NEH; ESTH

From the fall of Samaria through the ruins of Jerusalem and the banks of the Chebar to the rebuilt walls of the city.



Three Powers and One Small Land

This part spans about three hundred years, from the eighth to the fifth century BC, when the map of the Near East was changing faster than ever before. First Assyria rises, with its capital at Nineveh, and its armies reach the Jordan and the Nile. Then Babylon takes its place, and finally Persia, the largest state the world had yet seen. Between these powers live the small kingdoms of Israel and Judah, squeezed onto a strip of hills between the sea and the desert. The prophets Isaiah, Jeremiah and Ezekiel did not speak in a vacuum: they knew the roads, cities and armies they warned about.

The geography of this age is above all a geography of roads. The great routes from Mesopotamia to Egypt ran through the land of Israel or right beside it, so every military campaign began with the country lying in its path. Samaria fell in 722 BC and Jerusalem in 587 or 586, and part of the population walked hundreds of kilometers east, to the canals of Babylonia. Picture that march: weeks on the road, dust, the Euphrates alongside the route, and the question of whether God was still near. The books of 2 Kings, Jeremiah and Ezekiel answer it with remarkable honesty.

Yet this story does not end in ruins. The edict of Cyrus allows the exiles to return, and then Zerubbabel, Ezra and Nehemiah rebuild the Temple, the walls and a community gathered around the Law. The books of Esther and Daniel, meanwhile, show the life of those who stayed in the empire's great cities: in Babylon and Susa. In this part you will visit twelve places, from Assyrian Nineveh to the walls of Jerusalem, and look at four maps that put the events together into one picture. We give dates with caution: they are the conclusions of historians, and exact values are sometimes debated.

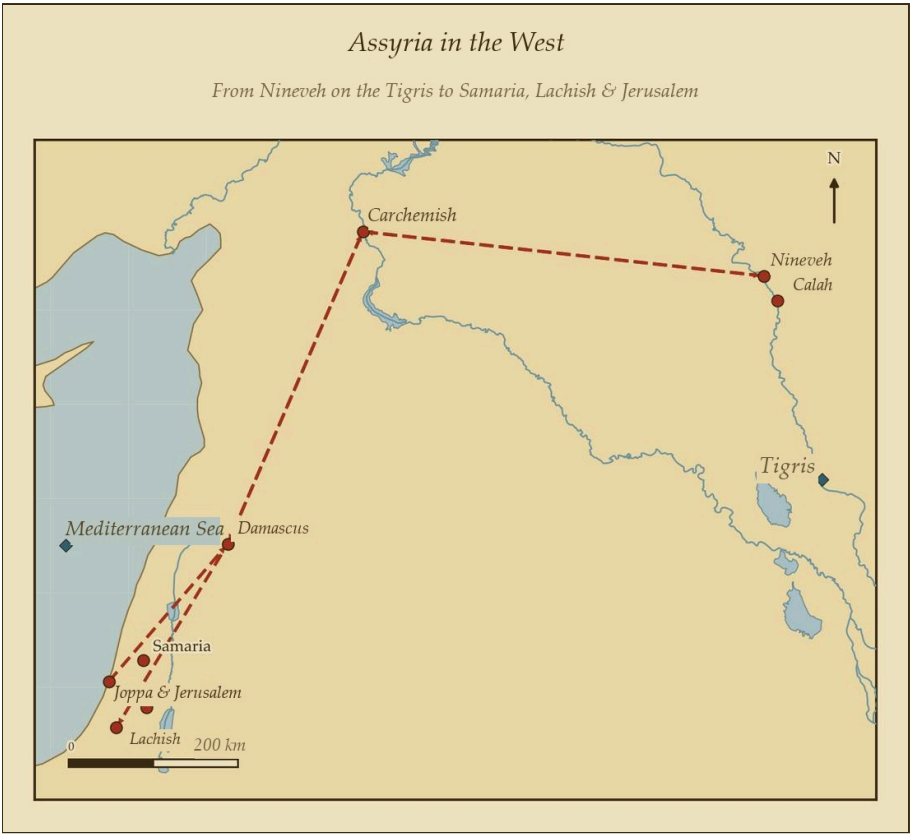
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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

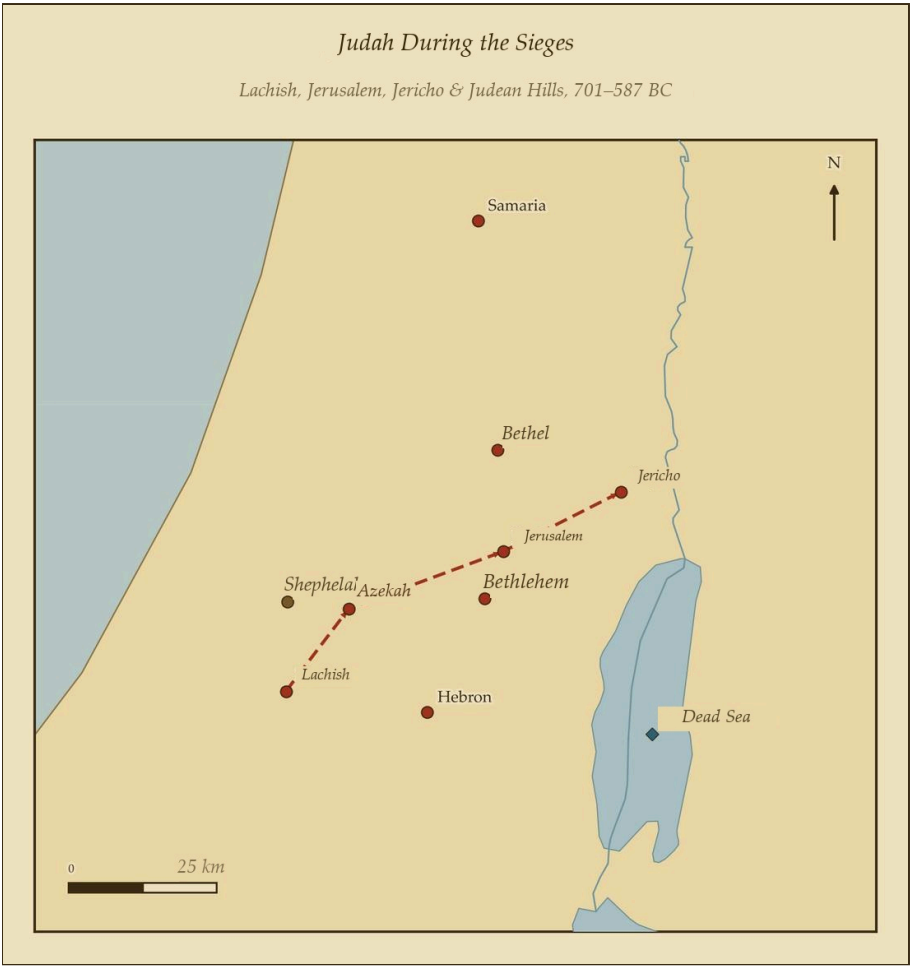
MAP 6.1



The dots mark cities and bodies of water, and the guide lines mark the routes taken by armies and messengers. They are not exact road courses.

The map shows why the small Northern Kingdom and Judah found themselves on the line of conflict. From Nineveh on the Tigris to Samaria was more than a thousand kilometers of marching, yet Assyrian armies covered such a distance every year. Their route ran through Syria, and the last stretches led across the coastal plain toward the hills of Judea. Note the position of Lachish: whoever controlled it had an open road to Jerusalem.

MAP 6.2



The vertical difference in elevation is the key to this map: in the west lies the Shephelah, in the middle the hills of Judea, in the east the deep Jordan Valley and the Dead Sea. The lines mark approximate routes of invasion and flight.

This map shows an area of about 100 by 130 km, and the events took place within it. Sennacherib's troops came from the west, from Lachish, climbing from the Shephelah toward the hills. Zedekiah fled east, toward the desert, and was

captured near Jericho. The map shows that Jerusalem stands in the mountains, whose slopes protect it from the east, and that access leads mainly from the west and north.

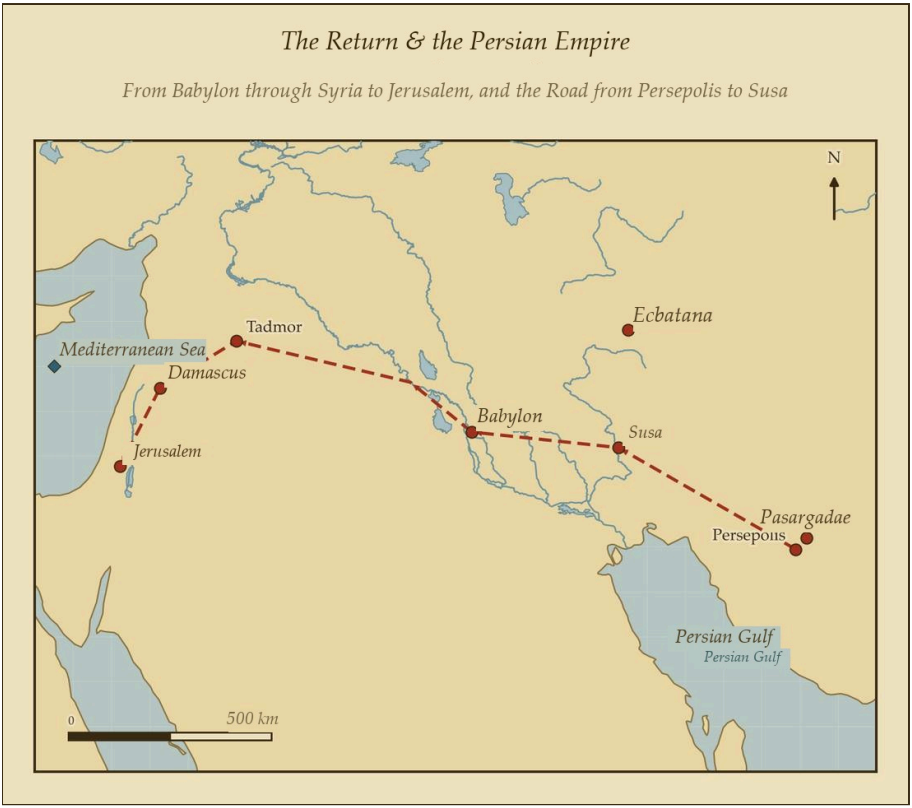
MAP 6.3



The map shows lower Mesopotamia, the plain between the Euphrates and the Tigris. The location of the Chebar near Nippur is traditional and uncertain.

The exiles came to a land as flat as a table, cut by a network of canals. In such a landscape farming depended on water, and cities like Babylon, Nippur and Uruk grew up along rivers and canals. Ezekiel lived beside one of them. It is worth noting that it was about 350 km from Babylon to Susa, so the Persians, who took over this region, could efficiently link east with west.

MAP 6.4



This map covers the western part of the Persian Empire, from the Mediterranean Sea to the Zagros Mountains. The lines are approximate routes, not exact road courses.

The road from Babylon to Jerusalem did not run in a straight line, because a caravan could not cross the Syrian Desert. Travelers went in an arc along the Euphrates, through Tadmor and Damascus, which made about 1,400 km. The map also shows that Susa lies in the middle of the empire: between Persepolis and Babylon. From such a place the Persian kings sent out the decrees that made the rebuilding of the Temple and the walls possible.

01 Nineveh

JONAH 1–4; NAH 1–3

The great capital of Assyria, to which God sends a reluctant prophet.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

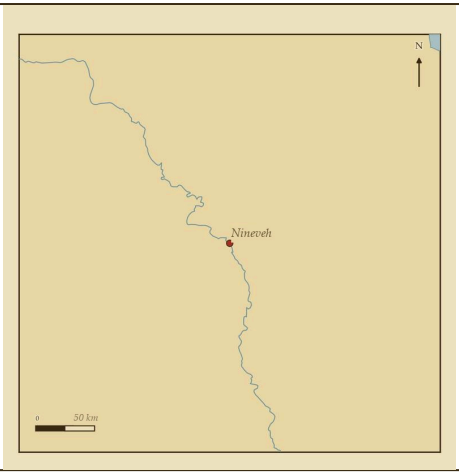
The artistic reconstruction shows a city surrounded by mighty walls with great gates, above which rise the terraces of palaces and temples. The walls of the buildings, made of sun-dried brick and faced with stone slabs, were adorned with reliefs of hunts and military campaigns. Caravans of donkeys mill about before the gate, and over the river canals and gardens can be seen. In the distance, on a hill, stands the tiny figure of a wanderer gazing at the immensity of the city.

The Book of Jonah tells of a prophet who is to go to Nineveh and warn its inhabitants of judgment. Jonah, however, boards a ship sailing the opposite way, and a storm and a stay inside a great fish finally send him obediently on his way. His short call brings repentance among the people, from the king to the animals. The prophet is surprised, and even resentful, at God's forgiveness. The book ends with God's question, addressed also to the reader, whether He has no right to take pity on so great a city.

Nineveh lay on the eastern bank of the Tigris, opposite present-day Mosul in Iraq, about 800 km in a straight line from Jerusalem. On foot, this meant many weeks of marching through Syria and northern Mesopotamia. Fertile plains, watered from the Taurus and Zagros mountains, could feed an enormous population. From here the armies of Assyria set out west, toward the coast of the Mediterranean. In going to Nineveh, Jonah was therefore going to the heart of the power that threatened his own nation. The mention of “a three days’ journey” probably refers to the extent of the city together with its surrounding settlements.

FACTS

The walls of Nineveh from the time of Sennacherib were about 12 km around.


N
Nineveh
0
50 km

02 Samaria

1 KGS 16:24; 2 KGS 17; AMOS 3–6

The capital of the Northern Kingdom, captured by Assyria in 722 BC.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a hill crowned by an acropolis with a royal palace, surrounded by a double wall of hewn stone. Below, on terraces, stand houses of stone and wood, and around them can be seen wheat fields, vineyards and olive groves. On a side road a column of captives winds along, guarded by soldiers: a symbol of the tragedy of 722. At the top of the hill the pale hewn stones of the palace gleam, and from the gates merchants with donkeys head down toward the valley.

King Omri founded Samaria as a new capital, and his successors, Ahab and the rulers after him, built it up into a magnificent city. Prophets such as Amos and Hosea, however, rebuked its people for injustice toward the poor and for worshiping foreign gods. According to 2 Kgs 17, Shalmaneser V besieged the city for three years, and his successor, Sargon II, according to Assyrian sources, finished the job in 722 or 721 BC. Part of the population was deported to Assyria and Media, and newcomers from other regions were settled in the land. The Northern Kingdom ceased to exist as a state.

Samaria stood on a solitary, oval hill rising about 100 m above the surrounding valleys, in the central hills of Ephraim. Its steep, easily defended position and the fertile fields around it explain why the city withstood such a long siege. At the same time, it lay close to important routes leading from the coast toward the Jordan Valley, which made it a tempting target. For Assyria, taking Samaria opened the way south, toward Judah, and secured the rear of campaigns aimed at Egypt. Today its remains lie near the Arab village of Sebastia.

FACTS

The hill of Samaria rises about 100 m above the surrounding valley; the siege lasted about 3 years.

03 Lachish

2 KGS 18:13–17; 2 CHR 32:9; MIC 1:13; ISA 36:1–2

The second most important fortress of Judah, captured by Sennacherib in 701 BC.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the city hill ringed with mighty walls and a gate, and on its slope a siege ramp, up which siege towers with battering rams climb. Archers fire on the walls, defenders hurl down burning torches, and smoke rises over the battlefield. In the background an Assyrian camp with commanders' tents can be seen. The scenes are shown from a distance, with no recognizable faces. Beneath the walls lie piles of stones, wooden ladders and a few surviving olive trees.

In the fourteenth year of King Hezekiah's reign, Sennacherib, king of Assyria, invaded Judah and captured many of its fortified cities. The books of Kings and Chronicles describe how his headquarters stopped at Lachish, from which envoys were sent to Jerusalem demanding surrender. Hezekiah tried to buy peace by sending a heavy tribute, but the Assyrians did not relent. The prophet Isaiah reassured the king, and God promised to save the city. The Book of Micah mentions Lachish in a bitter list of towns that will suffer the consequences of sin.

Lachish lay in the Shephelah, the foothills between the hills of Judea and the coastal plain, about 40 km southwest of Jerusalem. This position made it the guardian of the roads leading up to the capital from the coast and from Egypt. Whoever took it controlled access to the hills. The Assyrians did not storm the wall at a run: they built a great siege ramp of earth and stones, and the defenders answered with a counter-ramp of their own. Archaeology confirms both of these features. The scene of the capture of the city was also depicted in reliefs in Sennacherib's palace at Nineveh.

FACTS

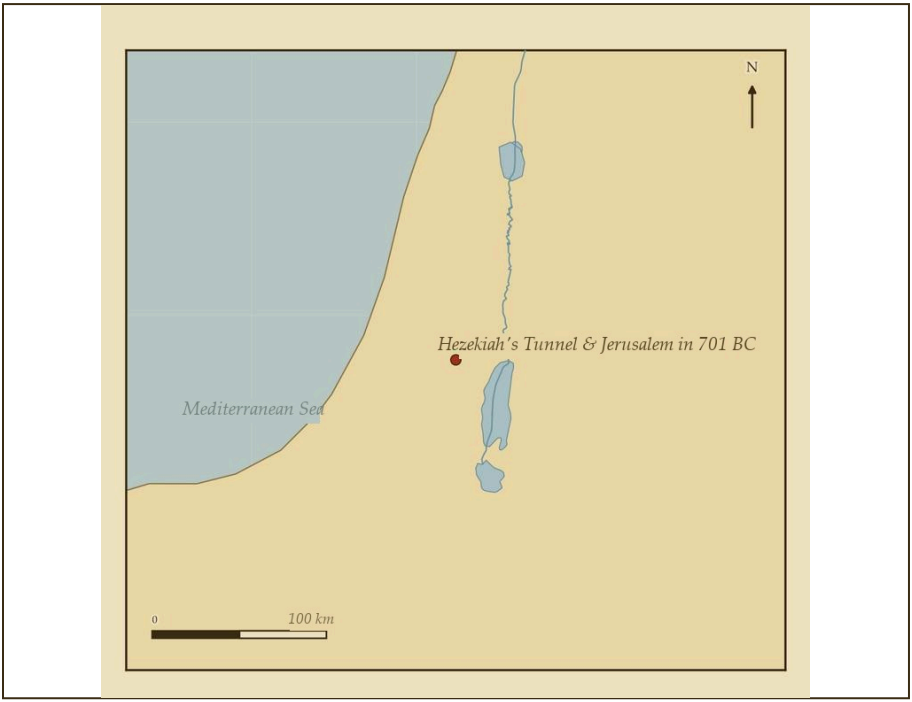
Distance from Lachish to Jerusalem: about 40 km in a straight line; the siege took place in 701 BC.


N
Lachish
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

04 Hezekiah's Tunnel and Jerusalem in 701 BC

2 KGS 18–20; 2 CHR 32:2–8, 30; ISA 36–37

Jerusalem prepares for a siege, and the water goes underground.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a narrow, cramped passage cut into the rock, with ankle-deep water and chisel marks on the walls. In the light of olive-oil lamps a dark stream can be seen flowing toward the pool, while on the surface of the hill rise the walls and towers of Jerusalem. At the mouth of the tunnel people draw water in jars, not yet knowing what the next day will bring. The rock smells of damp, and the coolness of the tunnel contrasts with the heat above.

6.4 · HEZEKIAH'S TUNNEL AND JERUSALEM IN 701 BC · 2 KGS 18–20; 2 CHR 32:2–8, 30; ISA 36–37

When Hezekiah saw that Assyria was approaching Jerusalem, he set about strengthening the city. According to 2 Chr 32, he repaired the walls, raised additional fortifications and saw to supplies. He also stopped up the springs outside the city so that the enemy would have no water, and he channeled water inside the fortifications. The Assyrian envoy called on the inhabitants to surrender, mocking their God, but Hezekiah prayed in the Temple. The Bible says the Assyrians withdrew from the city and Sennacherib returned to Nineveh.

Jerusalem lay on the narrow ridge of the City of David, about 700 m above sea level. The only permanent spring, Gihon, flowed outside the walls, in the Kidron Valley, and was exposed to seizure by the enemy. For this reason a tunnel about 530 m long was cut, which carries water through a rock channel to the Pool of Siloam inside the walls. It was dug from both ends at once, and the crews met in the middle. A stone inscription from Siloam, discovered in the nineteenth century, tells of this event. Today the tunnel is open to visitors; the water in it is sometimes high.

FACTS

Hezekiah's Tunnel is about 530 m long, and the difference in level between its two ends is only about 30 cm.

05 Jerusalem in 587 BC

2 KGS 25; 2 CHR 36:17–21; JER 39; 52; LAM 1–2

The destruction of the city and the first Temple by the armies of Nebuchadnezzar.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows Jerusalem burning at dusk: smoke rises above the ruined temple on the hill, and breaches gape in the walls. On the slope Babylonian soldiers move among ladders and siege towers, and a long, slow procession of people carrying bundles leaves the city. The whole scene is seen from a distance, in the reddish light of the fire. Through the breaches in the walls, the dark, deserted Kidron Valley can be seen.

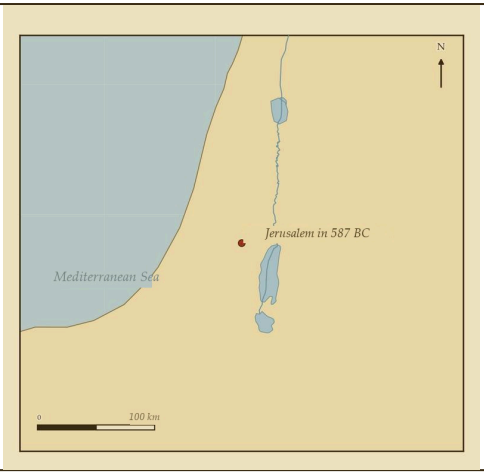
6.5 · JERUSALEM IN 587 BC · 2 KGS 25; 2 CHR 36:17–21; JER 39; 52; LAM 1–2

The last king of Judah, Zedekiah, rebelled against Babylon, so Nebuchadnezzar marched out with his army and besieged Jerusalem. According to 2 Kgs 25, famine took hold in the city, and after the wall was breached the king tried to flee toward Jericho but was captured. The Babylonians burned the Temple, the palace and the houses, and tore down the walls. Many of the inhabitants were carried off to Babylonia. Jeremiah, who had earlier warned of such a catastrophe, did not stop speaking about the future: he foretold a new covenant and a return. The Book of Lamentations expresses the pain of those days.

Jerusalem lay on a mountain ridge, surrounded by deep valleys, so it could be conquered mainly by starvation. That is why the siege lasted about 18 months. The Babylonian army marched from Mesopotamia along the Euphrates through Syria and reached the land of Judah after a march measured in weeks. Zedekiah's flight ran toward the Jordan Valley, about 25 km east, along a route descending about 1,000 m to the valley of Jericho. There, on the plain, the Babylonians overtook the fugitives. The scale of the fall is best shown by the difference in elevation between the capital and the desert.

FACTS

The siege lasted about 18 months; the destruction occurred in 587 or 586 BC.


N
Jerusalem in 587 BC
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

06 Babylon

DAN 1–6; ISA 13–14; JER 29; PS 137

The city of exile, where Daniel and his companions stayed faithful to their faith.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

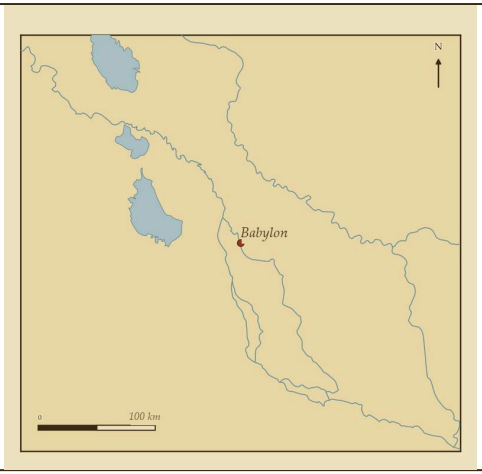
The artistic reconstruction shows the Ishtar Gate covered in gleaming blue glazed bricks, decorated with rows of lions, dragons and bulls. Before it runs the Processional Way, and in the background rises a stepped temple tower, a ziggurat. Merchants, priests and officials walk the streets, and palms stand beside the canal. The figures are seen from a distance, without facial detail. Everything is bathed in the warm, dusty light of noon.

The Book of Daniel tells of young men of Judah who were educated in Babylon in the palace school yet remained faithful to their faith. Daniel interprets the dreams of kings, his three friends refuse to worship a statue, and a later story mentions the lions' den. Jeremiah, in his letter to the exiles, urged them to build houses, plant gardens and seek the welfare of the city where they lived. Ps 137, in turn, conveys the longing by the rivers of Babylon. The community was learning to endure in a foreign world.

Babylon lay on the Euphrates, about 90 km south of present-day Baghdad, on a flat, fertile plain cut by a network of canals. The exiles were separated from Jerusalem by about 900 km in a straight line, which meant several months of marching. The Euphrates supplied water for fields and gardens and at the same time made it possible to trade by boat across all of Mesopotamia. Nebuchadnezzar II expanded the city: he built the Ishtar Gate and the Processional Way leading to the temple of Marduk. For newcomers from the hills of Judea, the flat, river landscape must have felt utterly foreign.

FACTS

Distance from Babylon to Jerusalem: about 900 km in a straight line; from present-day Baghdad: about 90 km.


N
Babylon
0
100 km

07 The Chebar River

EZEK 1–3; 10; 37; 40–48

A canal in Babylonia, beside which the prophet Ezekiel saw visions of God's glory.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a wide canal with clay banks, lined with palms and willows. On the bank stand low houses of sun-dried brick and huts, and people in simple robes draw water or work in the fields. In the distance the outline of a great city can be seen. The sky is vast and flat, which heightens the sense of distance from the mountains of home.

Ezekiel, a priest deported to Babylonia along with King Jehoiachin in 597 BC, begins his book with a vision by the Chebar River. There he saw the heavens opened, a wind, a cloud and an extraordinary throne, which pointed to God's presence among the exiles. He is commanded to be a watchman for his nation, and he proclaims first words of judgment and then of hope. The vision of the valley full of bones that come to life is a picture of the renewal of the community. The book ends with a description of a new Temple and a city where God will dwell.

The Chebar was not a river in our sense, but an irrigation canal branching off the Euphrates. It is traditionally sought in the area of the ancient city of Nippur, about 100 km southeast of Babylon; the location is uncertain. The exiles founded farming settlements here, cultivating fields watered by a network of canals. For a people attached to the Temple in Jerusalem, some 1,000 km away, this was a pivotal experience: God reveals Himself even in a foreign land, by the water, among ordinary people, and not only in one place.

FACTS

The Chebar Canal lay about 100 km southeast of Babylon; Jerusalem was about 1,000 km away.

08 Rebuilding the Temple in Jerusalem

EZRA 1–6; HAG 1–2; ZECH 1–8

The first returnees set up an altar, and after years of obstacles they complete the second Temple.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a hill full of scaffolding, piles of hewn stones and cedar beams. Workers carry blocks, in the background an altar stands under the open sky, and beside it a low, still unfinished building. Priests in white robes and Levites with instruments stand by the foundations. The whole scene is seen from a distance, in the warm light of morning.

6.8 · REBUILDING THE TEMPLE IN JERUSALEM · EZRA 1–6; HAG 1–2; ZECH 1–8

In 538 BC Cyrus, king of Persia, allowed the exiles to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the Temple. According to Ezra 2, about 42,000 people set out under the leadership of Zerubbabel and the high priest Joshua. First the altar was rebuilt, then the foundations were laid. Neighbors hindered the work, so construction stalled for years. The prophets Haggai and Zechariah encouraged the people to resume the work during the reign of Darius I. The Temple was completed and dedicated in 516 or 515 BC, and the community joyfully celebrated the Passover.

The road back from Babylonia usually followed the arc of the Fertile Crescent: along the Euphrates to the northwest, then through Syria to the south, about 1,400 km in all. Ezra, who returned several decades later, took about four months according to Ezra 7. The returnees found the city in ruins, shrunken to the ridge of the City of David and the Temple Mount. The new Temple was more modest than the former one; the elders who remembered the old sanctuary wept. Even so, it became the center of a community that endured for another five centuries.

FACTS

The road back from Babylonia was about 1,400 km; the second Temple was completed in 516 or 515 BC.

09 Susa

ESTH 1–10; NEH 1:1; DAN 8:2

The winter capital of the Persian kings and the setting of the story of Esther.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a palace with mighty columns topped with bull-shaped capitals, high terraces and walls of glazed brick bearing processions of guards. In the courtyard stand courtiers in long robes, and in the background gardens and the walls of the citadel stretch away. The figures are seen from a distance or from behind, in the warm, golden light of afternoon.

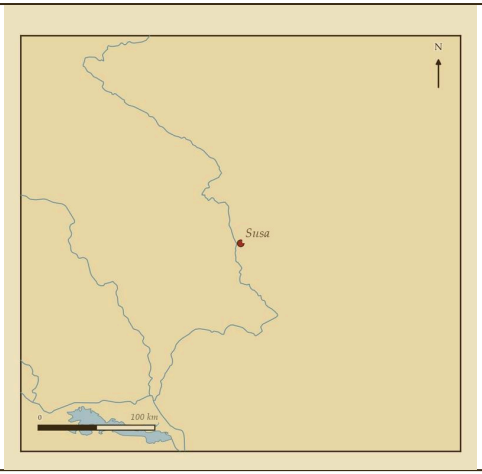
6.9 · SUSA · ESTH 1–10; NEH 1:1; DAN 8:2

The Book of Esther tells of a Jewish woman who becomes the wife of King Ahasuerus, probably Xerxes I. Through the counsel of her relative Mordecai, she uncovers a plot against her people and courageously stands before the king. The courtier Haman's plan is turned back, and the community celebrates the event as the feast of Purim. The beginning of the Book of Nehemiah also takes place in Susa: here a young Jew, the king's cupbearer, learns of the fall of Jerusalem's walls and asks the ruler for permission to go.

Susa lay in the fertile plain of Khuzestan, at the foot of the Zagros Mountains, about 350 km east of Babylon. The Persians made it one of their four capitals and the winter residence of their kings, because the city's climate was milder than on the plateau. From here the Royal Road set out, linking Susa with Sardis, about 2,700 km to the west. Thanks to it, embassies and orders reached the whole empire. Susa lay close to Persepolis (about 500 km) and yet close enough to Mesopotamia to control its busy, wealthy provinces.

FACTS

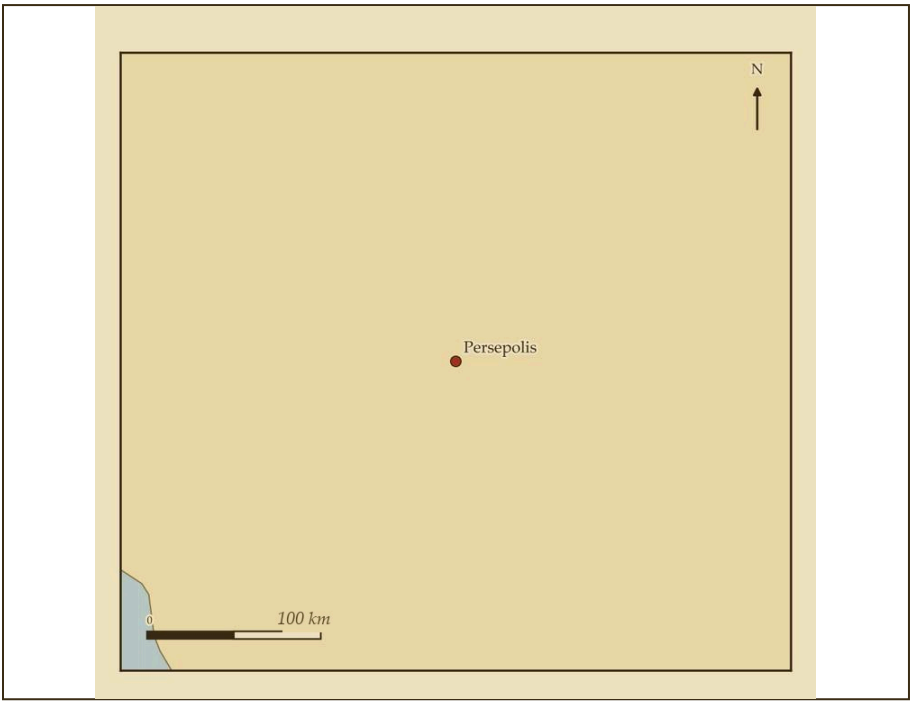
Susa lay about 350 km east of Babylon; the Royal Road from Sardis was about 2,700 km long.


N
Susa
0
100 km

10 Persepolis

EZRA 1:1–4; 6:1–12; ESTH 1:1–3

The ceremonial capital of the Persian Empire, which allowed the Jews to return.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a high stone terrace reached by broad stairways decorated with reliefs of processions. On the platform rises a forest of slender columns topped with the heads of bulls and lions, and before the Gate of All Nations stand mighty winged bulls. In the background a plain and rocky slopes can be seen, and delegates in varied dress make their way toward the stairs.

Persepolis does not appear in the biblical text, but it shows the world in which Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther act. The Persian kings, from Cyrus to Artaxerxes, ruled a vast empire from India to Egypt. Ezra 1 and 6 describe the decrees that permitted the rebuilding of the Temple and the payment of its costs from the royal treasury. Historians debate how far Persian tolerance extended, but documents of the period indicate that the rulers generally respected local cults. This allowed the people of Judah to re-create their community around the Temple.

Persepolis was founded around 518 BC by Darius I on the Marvdasht plain in the Zagros Mountains, about 500 km southeast of Susa, in the heart of the Persian province of Parsa. It was a ceremonial city, not a commercial one: here embassies from across the empire were welcomed at the New Year festival. The stairs of the Apadana are adorned with reliefs showing delegations bringing gifts. Thanks to the network of roads, including the Royal Road, governors from distant provinces, Judea among them, could keep in touch with the ruler. The palaces burned in 330 BC, after the invasion of Alexander the Great.

FACTS

Persepolis lay about 500 km southeast of Susa; its palaces were burned in 330 BC.

11 Nehemiah's Walls

NEH 1–7; 12:27–43

The rebuilding of Jerusalem's walls in only a few dozen days.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a hillside where a crowd of people are laying stone blocks in a new wall. Some carry baskets of rubble, others climb wooden scaffolding, and guards with spears stand on the little towers. Behind them the ruins of old houses can be seen, and in the distance the outline of the Temple Mount. The figures are shown from afar, in the light of early morning.

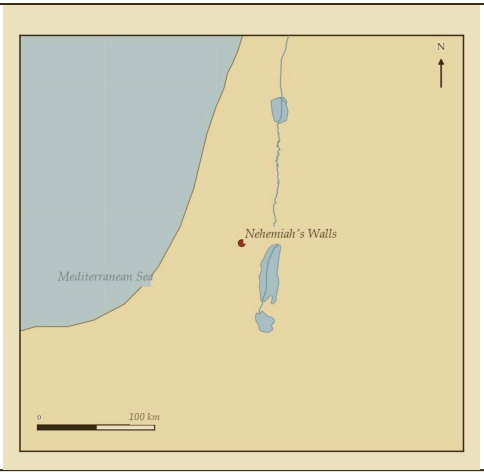
6.11 · NEHEMIAH'S WALLS · NEH 1–7; 12:27–43

Nehemiah, cupbearer to King Artaxerxes, heard in Susa about the ruined walls of Jerusalem and asked the king for permission to go. Around 445 BC he reached the city, rode around the ruins by night and called the inhabitants to rebuild. The book lists who built which section and which gate fell to which family. The enemies, Sanballat, Tobiah and Geshem, jeered, threatened and plotted, so the workers labored with a tool in one hand and a weapon in the other. According to Neh 6:15, the walls were finished in 52 days.

Jerusalem in this era was smaller than in Hezekiah's day. The walls enclosed mainly the ridge of the City of David and the Temple Mount, where a handful of families lived. Nehemiah had to patch breaches in the old lines of defense, using stones lying everywhere. The book lists about ten gates: the Sheep, Fish, Old, Valley, Dung, Fountain, Water and Horse Gates. Dividing the work by sections, with each group building by its own house, allowed the task to be finished quickly. The task was weakened by constant fear of attack from the neighbors.

FACTS

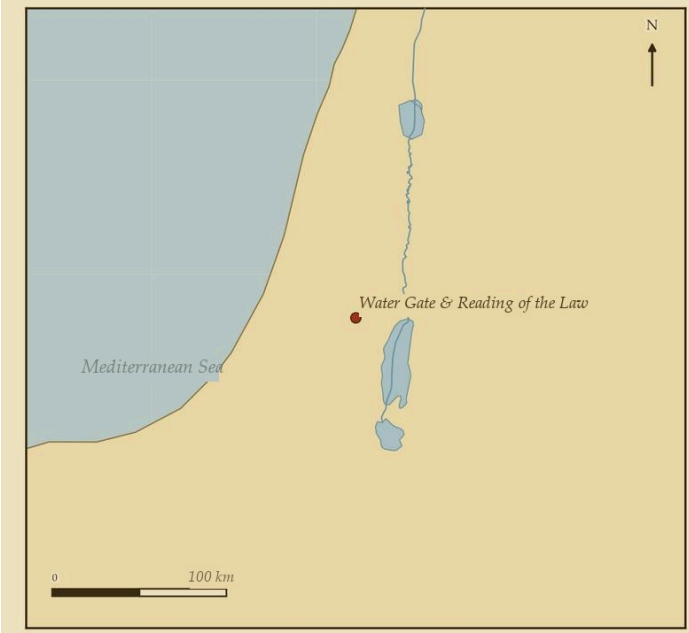
The rebuilding of the walls took 52 days (Neh 6:15); the work was completed around 445 BC.


N
Nehemiah's Walls
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

12 The Water Gate and the Reading of the Law

NEH 8–10; EZRA 7–10

The community gathers in the square to hear the Law and renew the covenant.



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a broad open square filled with a crowd in simple robes. On a wooden platform stands a figure with an unrolled scroll, and beside him Levites and priests. In the background rises the newly rebuilt wall with a gate, and the rooftops of the houses are covered with branches prepared for the Feast of Tabernacles. The whole scene is lit by bright morning light.

When the walls were ready, all the people gathered in the square before the Water Gate and asked Ezra to read the book of the Law. Ezra stood on a wooden platform, and the Levites translated and explained the text so that everyone could understand. The listeners wept, but Nehemiah and Ezra reminded them that this day was a holy day. Then the Feast of Tabernacles was kept, with people living in booths of branches. After that the community publicly renewed the covenant and pledged faithfulness, including support for the Temple.

The Water Gate led toward the Gihon spring, Jerusalem's only permanent spring, in the lower part of the City of David. The area before it was an open square where thousands could gather, including men, women and children able to understand. Ezra arrived in Jerusalem about four months after leaving Babylonia, most likely in 458 BC, though some scholars propose a different date. The reading lasted from dawn until midday and turned the rebuilt city into a community shaped by listening to the word.

FACTS

The reading of the Law lasted from dawn until midday (Neh 8:3); Ezra's journey to Jerusalem took about 4 months.

Questions for Reflection

1. How does your view of the events of 2 Kgs 17 and 25 change when you realize that Samaria and Jerusalem lay on the path of great empires? What follows from this for understanding the words of the prophets?

2. Ezekiel saw the glory of God by a canal in Babylonia, and Jeremiah urged the exiles to build houses and seek the good of the city. What do these images say about living out faith far from the homeland?

3. Nehemiah divided the work on the walls into sections, and Ezra read the Law before all the people. What significance do shared work and shared listening have in rebuilding a community?